CHAPTER 28

T20 WORLD CUP

30 April–16 May 2010

T20 World Cup, *West Indies*

I am under the assumption that I am going to play in the T20 World Cup in the West Indies in 2010. I have played well in the warm-up games and been involved pretty much throughout the build-up. It's an exciting team to be a part of, one with a lot of the boxes ticked, different types of players with great versatility filling a number of the more individualised and dynamic roles of short-form cricket. It feels, for once, like we're on the cusp of a modernisation of the game and ahead of the curve a little.

The day before the first game against the West Indies, we are on the field doing six-hitting drills. Paul Collingwood, his captaincy a part of the rhythm and verve with which we are playing, walks on to the field. I can tell from miles away, as he comes towards us, that he isn't coming to be involved and is instead armed with a task he doesn't necessarily want to do but is carrying out of duty. 'Jimmy, can I have a word,' he says. My heart sinks. I know this look, this conversation, this outcome.

'You won't be playing,' he tells me. I don't take it well. I say that I don't understand his decision. I leave the pitch sullen-faced, storming back into the dressing room, reverting to the boy who kicked his jumper back to the boundary for Burnley. As the tournament goes on, I begin to realise how well the team are performing and that it is obvious I won't be needed. I try to help out where I can, but I feel like an outsider and a bit-part in the squad. My interest wanes. I have an absolute distaste for not being involved, an irrational and horrible one that sits inside me like an alien rage,